

On Sweetness

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There was no famine in this age to drive your hand toward
excess,
no winter so merciless that it stripped the branches bare
and left you wandering beneath them with an empty mouth,
no field so cruel that it withheld its grain from you,
no earth so hostile that it denied your body bread,
and yet you, who stand surrounded by abundance,
who wake each morning beneath a world already offering itself,
still choose not merely to eat,
but to sweeten what was already whole,
to gild what was already sufficient,
to bend the plain and patient gifts of the earth
until they answer not to hunger,
but to restlessness.

For there is grain enough,
golden without being commanded into beauty;
there is fruit enough,
heavy on the branch,
so ripe it nearly breaks the wood that holds it;

there is milk enough,
quiet in its own fullness;
there is water,
the oldest mercy,
asking nothing of you except that you receive it.
All this the earth gives,
not with flattery,
not with deception,
not with that bright and fevered excess
by which men teach themselves to mistake stimulation for joy,
but with the ancient calm of things that do not beg to be desired.

And yet this is not enough for you.

Tell me, then, what hunger is this
that walks among people whose hands do not tremble,
whose bodies are not hollowed by want,
whose strength has not been thinned by deprivation;
what hunger is this that rises after the meal is finished,
that speaks after the body has already said enough,
that reaches not from need,
but from some darker obedience
learned so early and repeated so often
that it has put on the mask of the self?

You call it appetite,
and because the word is old,
you trust it.
You call it pleasure,

and because the moment is sweet,
you forgive it.
You call it a small thing,
a harmless thing,
a little cup crowned with cream,
a cold drink in the hand of a tired student,
a reward after labor,
a kindness after effort,
as though the smallness of a thing
could prove the smallness of its power,
as though what enters the body every day
does not also enter the will,
as though repetition were not one of the oldest forms of rule.

O young students,
you who carry your afternoons in paper cups,
you who lift to your mouths those shining mixtures
of milk, syrup, ice, and sweetness,
you who name them comfort
because they arrive dressed in the colors of comfort,
answer me honestly,
if honesty still has a room in you not rented out by habit:
is the thing in your hand only a drink,
or has it become a ceremony
through which your body is taught, again and again,
to confuse fatigue with craving,
loneliness with appetite,
effort with the right to be harmed?

You say,
I have worked, therefore I deserve this.
You say,
I am tired, therefore sweetness is mercy.
You say,
it is only once,
and then once becomes the language of every day,
and every day becomes the law under which the organs labor,
and the organs, having no voice with which to accuse you,
continue their silent obedience.

For the pancreas does not stand before you
like a prophet in the marketplace;
it does not tear its garment,
it does not cry out beneath the burden,
it does not tell you that it has been summoned too often
to drag the flood of sugar from the blood,
to command the gates of the cells to open,
to press the excess into liver,
into fat,
into the dim storehouses of the body
where what was once called pleasure
waits under another name.

It does not say,
I am tired.

It does not say,
you have mistaken my patience for permission.

It does not say,
every indulgence you refuse to remember
has been remembered by me.

And because it is silent,
you imagine yourself innocent.
Because the injury is gradual,
you imagine there is no wound.
Because the debt is paid inside the body,
you imagine there is no creditor.
But there is no mercy in a harm
merely because it has learned to move slowly.

What, then, do you place upon the tongue
with such obedience and such little suspicion?
What do you welcome into the body
before judgment has lifted its head,
before refusal has found its breath,
before the mind has asked
whether the wanting is truly yours?
Is it food,
or only the ghost of food,
a thing refined until it has lost the patience of grain,
the fiber of fruit,
the slowness of milk,
the humility of water,
a thing stripped clean of the very difficulty
by which nourishment teaches the body to be whole?

You say it is sugar,
as though the name were simple,
as though sweetness had not been separated from the field,
concentrated from the plant,
freed from the labor of chewing,
freed from the wisdom of slowness,
freed from every natural boundary
that once taught desire how to stop.

You say sugar,
and the word passes lightly through the mouth,
but the body does not receive it lightly.

The blood rises.

The organs answer.

The old machinery of survival,
which once served hunger with dignity,
is summoned now to serve a pleasure
that does not stay long enough
to deserve the name of satisfaction.

For what is this sweetness
that enters with brightness
and leaves with absence?

What is this pleasure
that promises fullness
yet teaches return?

What is this reward
that does not release the rewarded,
but binds him more tightly

to the hour in which reward must be repeated?
It touches the tongue and vanishes.
It lifts the blood and drops it.
It gives a brief light
and then sends the body back into shadow,
not nourished,
not completed,
but instructed to seek again
the thing that has just abandoned it.

And still you call this pleasure.

Tell me when pleasure became so brief
that it could no longer be received,
only pursued;
when satisfaction became so thin
that it could not settle into the body
before becoming memory;
when the mouth became a doorway
through which the world could enter
not to sustain you,
but to train you;
when desire ceased to rise from the body's wisdom
and began instead to arrive from outside,
wrapped in color,
priced in cups,
lit behind glass,
named as comfort by those who profit

from the exhaustion that comfort does not heal.

There was a time,
if the body is allowed its ancient testimony,
when enough was knowable.
There was a time when hunger had an end,
when the meal answered the lack,
when the body, receiving what it needed,
could fall back into peace.
But this other thing,
this glittering hunger without famine,
this craving without emptiness,
this reaching after completion has already been offered,
does not end.
It pauses only to begin again.

You eat,
and are not filled.
You reach,
and are not deprived.
You obey,
and call it choice.

What name shall be given
to the desire that survives its own fulfillment?
What name shall be given
to the appetite that remains
after the body has spoken clearly?
It is not hunger,

for hunger belongs to life
and life knows limits.
It is not need,
for need is honest
and does not disguise itself as celebration.
It is a lesson,
a law,
a discipline of return,
a sweetness that has entered the body
not as nourishment,
but as instruction.

Do not say freedom
when the desire has been rehearsed before you arrive.
Do not say choice
when the hand has learned the motion
before the mind has entered the room.
Do not say comfort
when the thing you call comfort
asks your organs to labor in silence
and leaves you colder than before.
Do not say harmless
because the wound does not announce itself at once.
The river hollows stone not by violence,
but by returning.

So too does habit hollow the will.

It does not need chains.

It does not need command.
It only needs the shape of reward
and the patience of repetition.
It comes dressed as kindness.
It sits beside your study,
beside your loneliness,
beside your fatigue.
It learns your hours.
It learns your weakness.
It waits where your discipline thins,
and when it speaks,
it speaks in your own voice.

This is the deepest cunning of it:
that the thing outside you
does not remain outside.
It enters first as taste,
then as pattern,
then as expectation,
then as need,
until the mouth believes it has chosen
what the body has only been trained to request.
And you defend it
because it is familiar,
as though familiarity were proof of innocence,
as though the return itself were evidence of belonging,
as though what has accompanied you
could not also have been weakening you.

But all captivity,
if visited often enough,
learns to resemble home.

Do not be deceived by the tenderness of the word sweet.
There are gentle names for violent things.
There are bright colors for dulling habits.
There are pleasures that arrive smiling
and leave the body less free than before.
What you have called sweetness
may be only the beautiful face
of a command repeated until it no longer sounds like command.

Look again at the cup in your hand.
Look past the cream,
past the syrup,
past the coldness that flatters the tongue.
Look at the bargain being made.
For a moment of brightness,
you ask the body to regulate the flood.
For a taste that does not remain,
you ask the organs to remember what the mind refuses.
For a pleasure too brief to become peace,
you offer the future labor of flesh
that has never abandoned you.

And should you not feel shame
before such loyalty?
Should you not lower your eyes

before the body that continues to serve you
even when you do not serve it?
It carries you through morning,
through study,
through grief,
through desire,
through the private hours when no one witnesses
how much effort it takes merely to remain alive.
And in return
you give it a sweetness
that calls itself reward
while increasing the debt.

I do not ask you to hate the tongue,
nor to despise delight,
nor to turn the world gray
in the name of purity.
The earth itself is not without sweetness.
The fruit ripens.
The milk warms.
The grain opens.
Honey exists,
and summer exists,
and the body was not made
to live without joy.
But joy is not the same as training,
and sweetness that belongs to the earth
is not the same as sweetness engineered

to make the hand return before the heart can question why.

There is a sweetness that nourishes,
because it arrives with substance,
with season,
with limit,
with the slow intelligence of the living world.
And there is a sweetness that empties,
because it arrives without patience,
without wholeness,
without memory of the plant from which it was taken,
and because it knows too well
how quickly the body can be made to answer.

This is the sweetness I accuse.

Not the fig heavy in sunlight.
Not the peach broken open in summer.
Not the small mercy of honey
where the body receives and is content.
I accuse the false sweetness,
the trained sweetness,
the sweetness that does not feed the life
but teaches the life to return to what fails it.

For every repetition writes something into you.
Every return deepens the road.
Every unexamined craving gives the next craving
a clearer path through the body.

And one day the wanting rises so quickly
that it feels older than thought,
more intimate than judgment,
almost sacred in its familiarity.
Then you say,
this is me.

But is it?

Is the self whatever has been repeated enough?
Is desire innocent because it speaks from within?
If a command is buried deeply enough in the body,
if it learns the warmth of your own voice,
if it waits behind fatigue and calls itself comfort,
does it become freedom,
or does freedom begin only when you can hear it as foreign?

Ask yourself this
before you lift the next sweet thing to your mouth.
Ask not only,
do I want it,
but who taught this wanting to arrive?
Ask not only,
will it please me,
but what will remain when pleasure leaves?
Ask not only,
is it small,
but how many small things have already become a life?
Ask not only,

is it mine,
but what part of me has been trained to defend it?

For the body is not your servant without memory.
It is the first house you were given,
the old companion that endures every bargain,
the silent animal walking beside your mind,
the faithful country over which every habit builds its road.
You may ignore it,
but you cannot leave it.
You may silence it,
but you cannot live elsewhere.
And every time you betray it
in the name of a sweetness that does not sustain you,
the betrayal returns to you
through the blood,
through fatigue,
through hunger that is not hunger,
through the strange sadness
that follows a pleasure too small for the damage it required.

Therefore do not turn away.

Do not hide behind the innocence of appetite.
Do not hide behind the smallness of the cup.
Do not hide behind the laughter of friends,
the language of reward,
the softness of cream,
the brightness of syrup,

the whole sweet theater
by which the world teaches you
to call obedience desire.

You live in abundance.
You are not starving.
The earth has not failed you.
The body has not refused you.
Yet you keep returning
to what does not complete you,
to what does not nourish you,
to what leaves you wanting the very thing
that made you want again.

So let the word sweetness
lose, for a moment,
its innocence.

Let it stand before you
not as a taste,
but as a question.

What has been trained in me?
What have I mistaken for desire?
What do I call comfort
because I have forgotten the shape of peace?
What do I call reward
because I no longer know how to rest
without being given something that harms me?

And if the answer unsettles you,
do not flee from it.
The beginning of freedom
is often the first honest discomfort
after a long obedience.

For what you swallow
is never merely what touches the tongue.
It becomes blood,
labor,
memory,
habit,
return.
It becomes the quiet schooling of appetite.
It becomes a law written beneath language.
It becomes the body learning
what the mind refuses to examine.

And if you repeat the lesson long enough,
the lesson will begin to answer
when someone calls your name.

So be careful
with what you call pleasure.
Be careful
with what you call small.
Be careful
with what you call yours.

For sweetness, when severed from nourishment,
is not mercy.
It is discipline.

It is not comfort.
It is rehearsal.

It is not the body speaking freely.
It is the body repeating
what the world has taught it to desire.

And every time you return
to the false sweetness
that brightens only to abandon you,
every time you ask your organs
to pay for a pleasure
that refuses to become peace,
every time you name obedience choice
because the chain has grown soft around the wrist,
you betray the body
that has never once
stopped carrying you.

You should feel guilty.

Not because joy is forbidden,
but because you have allowed a counterfeit joy
to feed upon your health.

Not because the mouth must be punished,
but because the body deserves to be believed.

Not because sweetness is evil,
but because false sweetness has taught you
to return to what empties you
and call the returning freedom.

You should feel guilty,
deeply guilty,
until guilt becomes not hatred of the self,
but the first clear mercy
you offer your body.